Policymakers and regulators must not get lost in the maze of the clearance process. Rather, they should focus on getting the right kind of technology and production processes that minimize the consumption of chemicals, fossil fuels and other materials that impact climate change or cause pollution without sacrificing national output or income.

The Environmental Impact Assessment Rules, 2006, which are currently in place, confer so much discretion on authorities granting consent that they often become tools in the hands of the minister and other officials to extract bribes by simply sitting on approvals. The average time taken to get one Category A project approval exceeds years.

These rules are under revision, with the government having notified the Draft Rules, 2020. As these rules clarify and simplify concepts and processes and set time limits on various stages, the environmental protection lobby, which has vested interests in perpetuating existing rentgenerating processes, have cried themselves hoarse. The government has been flooded with thousands of suggestions and it remains to be seen what emerges. In fact, the government should be more adventurous in the interest of growth and well-being of people to enhance industrial and infrastructure activities where environmental impacts can be easily absorbed or neutralized.

The construct should be simpler. If you intend to establish a thermal power plant based on coal, you need technology that ensures that, say, the carbon used per unit of power generated will not exceed ‘x’ kg. If you use such technology, no clearance should be required. Or, if you want to be aggressive on carbon control, one could take the decision to establish no coal-based plants in the country. These are policy choices that should be exercised with due caution and clarity. None of these policy decisions require the arduous process of assessment by ‘experts’ and consultations with people.